

Beyond Reservation: Tackling the “Sarpanch Pati” Syndrome in Rural Local Governance

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A woman wins a local election after campaigning in her village, earns the trust of her community and takes oath as the Sarpanch. Yet, when government officials visit the Gram Panchayat office, it is often her husband, father, or brother who attends meetings, signs documents and makes decisions on her behalf. The woman occupies the office, but the authority remains elsewhere.

This phenomenon, popularly known as the “Sarpanch Pati” syndrome, continues to persist despite Maharashtra reserving 50% of seats in Panchayati Raj Institutions for women. The policy has undoubtedly increased women's representation in local governance, but representation has not always translated into empowerment. In many villages, elected women continue to face social, administrative and institutional barriers that prevent them from exercising independent authority.

The reasons are complex. Reservation can provide a seat at the table, but it cannot instantly dismantle generations of patriarchal norms. Many first-time women representatives enter public office without prior exposure to governance, budgeting, administrative procedures or public decision-making. While they are entrusted with constitutional responsibilities, the support systems needed to help them perform these roles effectively often remain weak. In such situations, male family members frequently step in, creating a parallel structure of informal authority.

This issue has implications far beyond rural local bodies. The passage of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, which provides for women's reservation in Parliament and State Assemblies, raises an important policy question: Can political representation alone guarantee meaningful political participation? The experience of Panchayati Raj Institutions offers valuable lessons for the future of women's leadership in India.

Addressing this challenge requires moving beyond numerical representation. Capacity-building programs for newly elected women representatives must become more rigorous and continuous. Women's Self-Help Groups can be leveraged as support networks, while Mahila Gram Sabhas can provide platforms where women collectively articulate priorities and build confidence in public decision-making. Administrative processes should also be designed to ensure the direct participation of elected representatives rather than informal proxies.

Reservation was a historic step towards inclusive democracy. However, true empowerment will be achieved only when women are not merely elected to office but are able to exercise authority, influence decisions and lead governance independently. Maharashtra's villages offer an important reminder that democratic inclusion is not simply about who occupies the chair it is about who holds the power to govern.